



Chapter 1

User personas

Ages 3-6 · the co-play years

Who actually holds the phone, who is doing the learning, and who else is in the room. Deep, India-segmented personas so Chapter 1 stops designing for a generic child who does not exist.

The games feel shallow because the player is.

Not the child, the model of the child. The current Chapter 1 games are built for a generic "kid user": one tone, one difficulty, one loop. So they repeat, and repetition with no one specific in mind reads as boring. The fix is not more levels. It is a richer picture of who is on the other side of the screen.

Three reasons Chapter 1 feels flat today

WHAT'S HAPPENING	WHY IT BORES	WHAT A PERSONA CHANGES
A flat player model	One average child stands in for a bold 4-year-old, a shy 5-year-old, and a sensory-sensitive 5-year-old who need completely different pacing.	Three child temperaments, each with its own pacing, reward and failure rules.
One mechanic on repeat	"Tap the correct card" is the whole game. After three screens the child has met every idea the loop can hold.	Goals and frustrations that demand variety: sorting, pretend, story, voice, movement, co-play.
No one else in the room	At 3-6 there is no solo player. A parent holds the phone and a grandparent may be watching, often carrying the very bias we are unlearning.	The co-player becomes a designed role, not a bystander.

This document is a brief, not a description. Eight personas, three Indian segments, three roles. Each one ends in concrete design implications for the six Chapter 1 games: Feelings Friends, My Body My Rules, Clean Crew, My Family Garden, Same Same Different, and Can-Do Kids.

Eight people, one living room.

At this age the product is really played by a small group, not an individual. Here is the whole cast and the single lever each one gives us for making Chapter 1 deeper.

PERSONA	ROLE	SEGMENT	IN ONE LINE	THE LEVER FOR DEPTH
Megha Rao, 34	Parent	Metro, dual-income	Anxious about screens, hungry for "good" ones.	Earned trust: visibly worth the screen time.
Sunita Yadav, 38	Parent	Tier-2, joint family	Modern values, traditional living room.	Bridges elders: gives her cover, not conflict.
Razia Sheikh, 29	Parent	Low-income, first-gen smartphone	One shared phone, big aspirations, real fear.	Tiny data, tiny sessions, safety framing.
Vihaan, 4	Child	Metro	Fast, loud, taps everything twice.	Movement and surprise inside the loop.
Aria, 5	Child	Tier-2	Watches first, wants to be "good".	Safe-to-be-wrong, feelings made legible.
Kabir, 5	Child	Low-income	Sensory-sensitive, deep on his favourites.	Calm mode, predictability, no fail states.
Ms. Fernandes, 41	Educator	Urban private preschool	20 kids, circle time, cautious about tech.	Group mode and a parent bridge.
Anjali, 26	Educator	NGO / anganwadi	One tablet, many languages, few resources.	Offline, multilingual, low-literacy safe.

Children are loosely paired to the parents above (Vihaan with Megha, Aria with Sunita, Kabir with Razia) so the segment and the temperament can be read together.

Megha Rao, 34

Product manager · Bengaluru · nuclear family · the screen-anxious optimiser

"I'll happily give him the iPad - if it's actually doing something. I just don't want another dopamine machine."

HOME	2-BHK flat, Bengaluru. Nuclear: Megha, husband Arjun, son Vihaan (4).
LANGUAGES	English at home, Kannada / Hindi around them.
DEVICES	iPad (Vihaan's), two iPhones; fast wifi.
CARE	Montessori-style daycare 9-3; a nanny after.
MONEY	Comfortable; will pay for quality, hates being sold to.

A Tuesday, 7pm. Dinner is late, Vihaan is wired, and Megha needs twenty minutes. She reaches for the iPad with a small knot of guilt. She has tried "educational" apps that were just dressed-up flashcards; she scrolls reviews while he plays, half-watching, ready to judge whether this one is junk. If it is, it is deleted by Thursday.

What she wants

- Screen time that earns its place: she can see him learn something real.
- Calm, not hyper-stimulating; nothing that leaves him cranky.
- Values she cares about (kindness, fairness) woven in, not preached.
- A way to join in for two minutes and then hand it over.

Why she'd bounce

- It looks like a worksheet, or like loud junk. Either is an instant delete.
- It repeats: she sees the same tap-the-card screen recoloured.
- It nags for streaks, coins, or in-app purchases.

BORING TO MEGHA

A pastel quiz that drills "which one is the doctor". She has seen it, and so has he.

The bias she models (gently)

Well-meaning and mostly invisible to her. She buys Vihaan blocks and cars, his cousin dolls and kitchen sets. She tells him "be brave, don't cry," and praises a niece for being "so well-behaved and pretty."

Boys are just better at building.

Big boys don't cry.

She would be mortified to hear it called bias. That is exactly why Lensy asking "why?" lands better than any lecture.

MAGIC TO MEGHA

Vihaan turns to her unprompted and asks "why is that a boys' toy?" The app started a conversation she did not have to force.

Design implications

- 1 Build a 90-second "show a parent" moment per session: one screen Megha can glance at that proves a real idea landed.
- 2 Give the co-player a real role (read the line aloud, pick together), so handing over the iPad is part of the design, not a failure of it.

- 3 Default to calm motion and audio; never end a session on a hyper note. Respect reduced-motion and a volume-off path.
- 4 Reward with stickers and story beats, never streaks, coins or purchase prompts.

Sunita Yadav, 38

Homemaker, part-time tuition teacher · Indore · joint family · the bridge

"I want my daughter to grow up differently. But it is her grandparents' house too, and I have to live in it."

HOME	Joint family: husband, his parents, son (8) and daughter Aria (5).
LANGUAGES	Hindi at home; wants the kids' English strong.
DEVICES	One shared Android; a prepaid data pack she rations.
CARE	Local English-medium school; grandparents mind the kids.
MONEY	Single income; careful. Value for money matters.

A Sunday afternoon. The TV is on, dadi is resting, and Aria wants the phone. Sunita says yes, but the living room is shared: whatever Aria plays, her grandmother half-hears. When a game once mentioned "your body", dadi frowned and asked what kind of app this was. Sunita is not against the idea. She just cannot be seen to import something that picks a fight with the elders.

What she wants

- Modern, fair ideas for her daughter, delivered so they do not provoke the elders.
- Visible "education" value (English, manners) that earns the family's approval.
- Short sessions she can supervise while doing three other things.
- Something her son and daughter can both use, fairly.

The bias in the room

Less hers than the household's, and stronger for it. Aria is asked to help in the kitchen while her brother is not; he is served first; "what will people say" governs a lot.

Kitchen and cleaning are girls' work.

Boys shouldn't have to help at home.

Sunita is the bridge. The product wins by handing her language and cover, not by handing her an argument.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything that feels like it is criticising the family or "Western".
- Body or consent content with no framing she can defend to dadi.
- Heavy downloads or data drain on a rationed pack.

BORING TO SUNITA

A lecture-y game that "teaches gender equality" in a way she would never play within earshot of her mother-in-law.

MAGIC TO SUNITA

A fairness game framed as "everyone helps the family" that dadi nods along to, while it quietly retires "girls' work".

Design implications

- 1 Frame sensitive ideas in family-safe language ("everyone helps", "staying safe") that a watching elder can accept; keep an elder-friendly tone option.
- 2 Make body and safety nodes openly about safety and trusted adults, with a one-line "why this matters" a parent can show.
- 3 Ship light: small downloads, an offline-once-loaded mode, low data use per session.

- 4 Support fair turn-taking between two siblings on one device, so "fairness" is modelled by the product itself.

Razia Sheikh, 29

Domestic worker · peri-urban Hyderabad · one shared phone · aspiration on a budget

"If it teaches him good things and a little English, I will find the time. But the phone is also my work."

HOME	One room; husband drives an auto; son Kabir (5), a baby.
LANGUAGES	Urdu / Telugu; very little English; reads slowly.
DEVICES	One budget Android, hers, also used for work calls; tight data.
CARE	Low-cost private LKG; some days an anganwadi.
MONEY	Daily-wage; every rupee and megabyte counts.

After 9pm. Work is done, the baby is down, and Kabir gets the phone for a little while before sleep. Razia cannot read most of the screen, so if the app does not talk, she cannot help. She worries about "wrong" things online and about strangers. She would never use a word like "consent", but she desperately wants her son to be safe and to get a head start she never had.

What she wants

- Her son to be safe, kind, and a step ahead, especially in English.
- An app that talks, so a parent who reads slowly can still take part.
- Tiny sessions that sip data and battery.
- Nothing that shames her or feels "not for people like us".

Why she'd bounce

- Text-heavy screens she cannot read or explain.
- Big downloads, constant connectivity, or data-hungry video.
- Body content with no clear, respectful "this is about safety" frame.

BORING (AND USELESS) TO RAZIA

A silent, text-led game. If it does not speak, it does not exist for this household.

The bias she carries

Born of love and scarcity. Safety means restriction, especially for daughters; "stranger danger" is the whole story, when most real risk is a known adult; bodies are not discussed.

Only strangers are dangerous.

Talking about bodies is shameful.

She is not resistant, she is unserved. Audio-first, dignity-first design reaches her where text-first design never will.

MAGIC TO RAZIA

Kabir proudly "reads" a safety idea aloud in English that the app voiced, and tells her a trusted grown-up can help.

Design implications

- 1 Audio-first, always: every prompt voiced, so a low-literacy parent and a pre-reading child can both play. Never gate meaning behind text.
- 2 Engineer for scarcity: small install, offline play once loaded, low data, low battery, works on budget Android.
- 3 Replace "stranger danger" with "trusted grown-up" and body-safety as safety, in warm, non-shaming, multilingual voice.

- 4 Design two-minute complete sessions, so a late, tired, borrowed-phone window still finishes something whole.

THE LEARNER

Vihaan, 4

Metro · high-energy · "the double-tapper"

"Again! Again!" ... then, thirty seconds later, "I'm bored."

Where he is, developmentally

- Attention in bursts of roughly 6-10 minutes, less if it does not move.
- Pre-reader. Learns by doing, watching, and a lot of repetition.
- Big motor energy; taps fast, double-taps, drags imprecisely.
- Fairness radar switching on: "that's not fair!" is a new, powerful phrase.
- Tests "no" and rules constantly; loves cause-and-effect and surprise.

BORING TO VIHAAN

The third "tap the right card" screen in a row. He has solved the pattern and now he is just clicking.

What he's already absorbing. Vihaan has started sorting the world: "that's a girl colour", "boys don't play with that". He repeats YouTube catchphrases verbatim. He wants to be "a big boy", which to him already means not crying. None of this is fixed yet. That is the whole window.

What delights him

Things that react: pop, wobble, sound, a doodle that springs to life. Being the one who makes something happen. Silliness. Winning, then doing it again with a twist.

MAGIC TO VIHAAN

He drags a toy to "anyone can play with this" and the whole canvas cheers, a doodle does a backflip, and the next bit is different.

Design implications

- 1 Vary the verb: alternate tapping with dragging, sorting, "shouting" into the mic, tilting, pretend. One mechanic per node, never the same twice running.
- 2 Reward motion and cause-and-effect: every correct action does something visible and a little surprising.
- 3 Forgive fat fingers: big targets, double-tap tolerance, no penalty for a mis-tap.
- 4 Use his fairness radar as the hook at age 4: "is that fair?" beats "is that correct?".

THE LEARNER

Aria, 5

Tier-2 · observant · "the good girl"

"Did I get it right? Was that good?"

Where she is, developmentally

- Watches before she acts; quietly competent once she feels safe.
- Language-rich and bilingual; loves stories, songs and pretend.
- Reads tone keenly; a harsh "wrong!" buzzer can make her stop playing.
- Strong urge to please adults and "be good"; risk-averse.
- Beginning to read others' feelings; empathy is blossoming.

BORING (OR SCARY) TO ARIA

A speed quiz with a red "WRONG" buzzer. She will freeze, then disengage to avoid getting it "wrong".

What she's already absorbing. Aria is learning that "good girls" are quiet, helpful and do not make a fuss, and that some feelings (anger, "no") are not for her. She helps in the kitchen while her brother plays. She is wonderful at caring for others and is quietly learning to put herself last.

What delights her

Stories with characters she can help. Gentle praise. Pretend and dress-up. Being trusted with a "grown-up" choice. Singing along.

MAGIC TO ARIA

A story where she helps a character say "I feel sad" out loud, and learns that "no" and big feelings are allowed, for her too.

Design implications

- 1 Make it safe to be wrong: no harsh fail states, no buzzers; a "wrong" answer becomes a gentle "let's look again".
- 2 Lead with story and character she can help, not drills; let empathy be the mechanic.
- 3 Actively validate "no" and the full range of feelings, so the quiet, pleasing child hears that her boundaries and anger are allowed.
- 4 Praise the choice and the thinking, not being "good" or "pretty".

THE LEARNER

Kabir, 5

Low-income · sensory-sensitive, routine-loving · "deep, not wide"

(Says little. Lines the animals up in the same order, every single time, and is perfectly happy.)

Where he is

- Sensory-sensitive (likely neurodivergent, undiagnosed): loud or flashy overwhelms him.
- Speech is a little delayed; he understands far more than he says.
- Loves predictability and routine; thrives on the same loop done well.
- Capable of deep, long focus on a favourite, on his own terms.
- Sudden change or a fail buzzer can tip him into shutdown.

What the world gets wrong about him. Kabir's overwhelm is often read as "naughty" or "slow". He is neither. With a calm, predictable design he is one of the most engaged players of all. He also needs body-safety and consent ideas made unusually concrete and literal, because subtle social cues are harder for him.

OVERWHELMING TO KABIR

Loud cheers, flashing confetti, a timer, an unexpected scene change. He puts the phone down and walks away.

MAGIC TO KABIR

A calm mode: same gentle loop, predictable steps, no timer, no fail. He plays the same node ten times and learns it cold.

Design implications

- 1 Ship a calm mode: reduced motion and sound, no timers, no fail states, predictable step order. This is the same switch Megha and Razia want at bedtime.
- 2 Make consent and body-safety concrete and literal, not reliant on subtle facial or social cues.
- 3 Let repetition be a feature: replaying the same node is mastery, and should be rewarded, not nudged away from.
- 4 Accept many input styles and pace; never punish silence, slowness, or a long pause.

FACILITATOR

Ms. Fernandes, 41

Lead teacher, private preschool · Mumbai · 20 little ones, one screen

"Give me something for circle time that I can stop in ten seconds when someone cries."

Her reality

- 20 children, ages 3-5, one shared classroom screen or projector.
- Runs circle time; needs whole-group, low-prep, interruptible tools.
- Tech-curious but cautious; will not risk chaos or screen-time blowback from parents.
- Trusted by parents; her recommendation travels.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Not a solo app on twenty tablets. A group mode for the projector: one big myth on the wall, children vote by hands or by coming up to tap, a clean pause, and a short note home so parents continue it. She is the multiplier who turns one node into twenty conversations.

USELESS TO HER

A single-player, headphones-on, login-per-child app. It cannot survive a circle of twenty.

MAGIC TO HER

One screen, the whole class voting on "is that fair?", then a one-tap "send today's idea to parents".

Design implications

- 1 Offer a group / projector mode: one shared canvas, whole-class voting, big legible visuals.
- 2 Make every node interruptible and resumable; a clean pause for when a three-year-old needs her.
- 3 Provide a 30-second "continue at home" handoff she can send to parents, turning school into co-play.
- 4 Keep prep near zero: no per-child logins, no setup, works on whatever screen the room has.

FACILITATOR

Anjali, 26

NGO field facilitator / anganwadi support · peri-urban & rural

"My classroom speaks three languages and the internet comes and goes. Whatever you build has to work anyway."

Her reality

- Mixed-age groups, several home languages, very few resources.
- One shared tablet or a borrowed projector; power and data are unreliable.
- Works with low-literacy parents; she is often the only "reader" in the room.
- Foundational priorities: safety, hygiene, feelings, fairness.

UNUSABLE TO HER

An online-only, English-only, text-heavy app. It fails on the first power cut.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Offline-first content that runs with no signal, narration in the local language, and visuals that carry meaning with almost no text. She extends our reach into exactly the homes that text-first edtech never touches, but only if it survives her conditions.

MAGIC TO HER

A pack she preloads once, plays offline all week, in the children's own language, with picture-led safety ideas.

Design implications

- 1 Offline-first: a chapter pack that preloads and runs with no connectivity, light on power.
- 2 Multilingual narration and picture-led design, so meaning never depends on reading.
- 3 Prioritise the foundational, locally urgent nodes (safety, hygiene, feelings, fairness) for low-resource settings.
- 4 Give her a simple facilitator path: pick a node, play to the group, no account needed.

What Chapter 1 must do differently.

Read across all eight personas and the same few principles keep surfacing. These are the levers that turn "boring, repetitive and shallow" into something a tired parent, a wired four-year-old and a careful teacher all come back to.

PRINCIPLE	BECAUSE	SHOWS UP AS
One mechanic per node, never repeated	Vihaan solves a loop in seconds; repetition is the core "shallow" complaint.	A varied verb set: sort, drag, pretend, voice, move, co-play, story.
Design the co-player in	No one is solo at 3-6; the adult is the operator and often the bias.	Read-aloud roles, a "show a parent" beat, an elder-safe tone, a send-home.
Audio-first, text-optional	Every child is pre-reading; Razia reads slowly; Anjali's room is multilingual.	Full narration, picture-led screens, multilingual voice.
Three paces, one node	Bold, careful and sensory-sensitive children need different speeds.	A calm mode, adjustable pace, big targets, gentle "look again" instead of fail.
Safe to be wrong	Aria freezes at a buzzer; Kabir shuts down; fear kills depth.	No harsh fail; mistakes become the next gentle question.
Ask, don't grade	Fairness ("is that fair?") engages far more than correctness at this age.	Lensy's "why?" as the hook; reflection over right answers.
Built for scarcity	Shared phones, tight data, power cuts, budget devices are the norm.	Small, offline-capable, low-data, two-minute complete sessions.
Reward with story and stickers	Parents reject dopamine loops; the brand uses stickers as the only currency.	Sticker payoffs and story beats; no streaks, coins or purchases.

The same principles, on the six Chapter 1 games

GAME	THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS
Feelings Friends (g01)	Story-led, empathy as the mechanic; explicitly allow "no" and anger (for Aria); name feelings aloud (for Kabir, Razia).
My Body, My Rules (g02)	Safety framing dadi and Razia can accept; concrete and literal for Kabir; "trusted grown-up", not "stranger danger".
Clean Crew (g37)	Calm, routine-friendly loop (Kabir); everyone-helps framing that sidesteps "girls' work" (Sunita's home).
My Family Garden (g03)	Show many real family shapes, including single parents and joint families, so every child in the room sees theirs.

Same Same, Different (g04)

Drag-and-cheer fairness for Vihaan; "is that fair?" hook; retire "boys' / girls' toys and colours".

Can-Do Kids (g05)

Anyone-can-do-any-job, co-played so a parent's own assumption gets a gentle "why?" too.

Next: the same persona lens for Chapters 2-8, then a Chapter 1 game-by-game redesign built directly on this brief.